

A gentleman's game and a civil servant's duty

Javed Burki reflects on his cricketing journey, from Pakistan's 1960-61 India tour to his civil service career, recalling friendships, discipline, and the game's evolution.

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“I play golf every day. That's part of my routine,” says Javed Burki as we walk around his house in one of the elite neighbourhoods of Islamabad. It has been raining for the past few days, causing the temperature to drop further. As he takes me to his garden, Burki introduces me to his pet dog, Shadow.

“Be careful, he is very friendly, but if you ignore him, he will start jumping,” Burki smiles before engaging in a game of throw-ball with his pet. A former Pakistan captain, erstwhile chief national selector, and civil servant, Burki will turn 87 in a couple of months. But age, clearly, has not caught up with him.

The word ‘discipline’ repeatedly comes up in our conversation as Burki turns back the clock and recalls his first visit to India with the Pakistan Test team in December 1960. He was just 22 then and among the youngest members of the squad, led by the legendary Fazal Mahmood.

All five Test matches in the series ended in a draw — unimaginable in today's era. “But those days were different,” he says. “Even after the India series, when we played against Australia and New Zealand, it was the same story — we did not win, we did not lose, but we drew...”

Four months before the team left for India, Burki returned to Pakistan from England to prepare for the civil services examination in November. “Around October, they held trials to select the team for India. I was picked, but I told the selectors I would not be available for the first few tour matches due to the examination,” he says.

Once the examination was over in late November, he arrived in Bombay — modern-day Mumbai — for the first Test. But Burki faced an unexpected challenge upon checking in at the Cricket Club of India premises. “Since returning from England, I had been busy preparing for the civil service examination. As a result, I hadn't been exposed to much of the subcontinental sun. And in Bombay, the sun was so bright that I felt very uncomfortable,” he remembers.

He requested that the team management not consider him for the first test at the Brabourne Stadium. “I wanted to acclimatise. But the team management rejected my request and said I'd have to play...”

It was not an outing to remember, as he scored just seven runs in the first innings before falling to Subhash Gupte. Though he remained unbeaten on 13 in the second, Burki did not have much to write home about.

But off the pitch, there were memorable moments.

Starry experiences

“Yusuf Khan, who?”

Burki remembers asking a gentleman this question at a party hosted by the noted filmmaker and producer Mehboob Khan in Bombay. The gentleman appeared awkward, as Burki failed to recognise him. “The first day, he introduced himself as Dilip Kumar, and a couple of days later, he walked up to me and said, ‘I am Yusuf Khan, remember me?’ And my answer was — ‘no’...” Burki says with a smile.

Back then, Burki was unaware that Dilip — the revered actor — was originally known as Yusuf Khan. “And that led to the confusion. But he was a very nice man, and we had a great time discussing his roots in Peshawar and his family,” he recalls.

During that tour, Burki also met yesteryear actors Ashok Kumar and Raj Kapoor, as well as the illustrious Saira Banu, who later married Dilip. “Back then, they weren't married. And when we were in Bombay, Fazal (Mahmood) and I socialised with many people from the film industry, and it was a great experience,” he



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